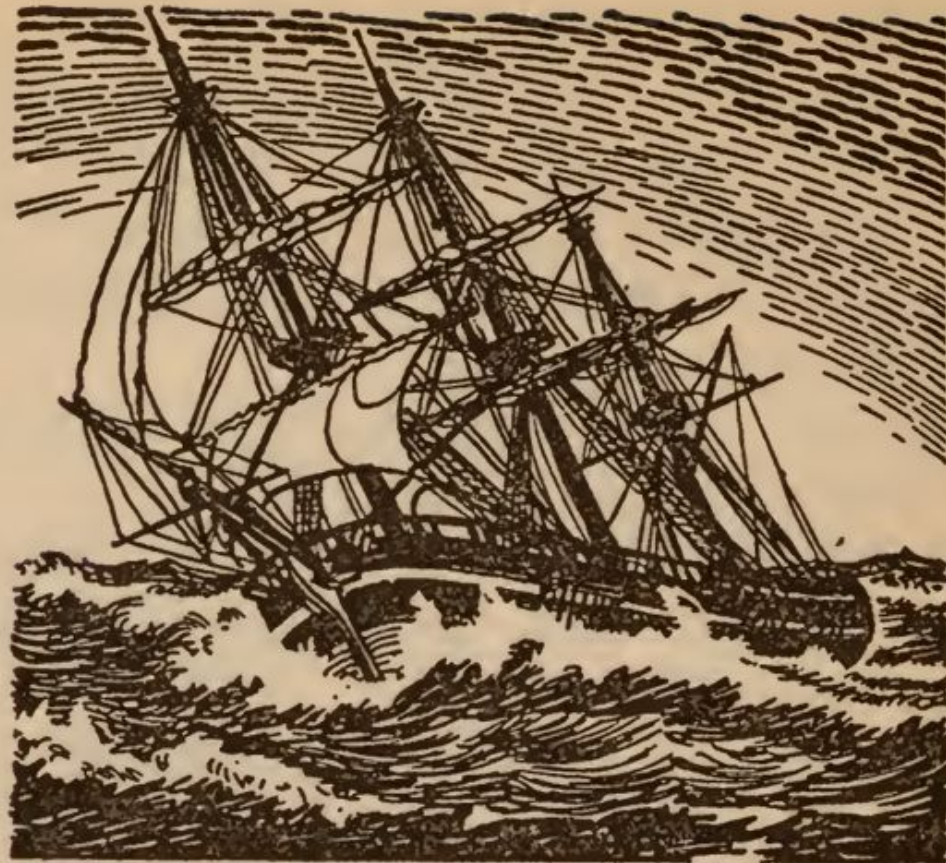


Carry On, Mr. Bowditch

Chapter 23



CHAPTER 23



CAPTAIN BOWDITCH COMMANDING

"Come along with me, Nat," Dr. Holyoke suggested. "You might as well help set a leg. Six months from now, you might be bossing the job."

When they turned in at Lem's gate, they could hear him raging. When Lem saw them, he broke out afresh. He'd been mending the shingled roof of their little house when the ladder had slipped sideways. He'd tangled with it as he'd fallen.

"Me!" he stormed. "Me fall off of a house! Me that's hung by my eyebrows, reefing sail in a storm! Fix me up good, Doc, so I can be ready when the *Putnam* sails."

"Not a chance of it, Lem. This is a compound fracture."

“Now, listen, Doc — ”

“Shut up, man! You’d be a nuisance on shipboard!”

“Oh . . .” Lem was silent. “Then, listen, Captain Bowditch. There’s a lot I’d better tell you. When you hit the coral reefs off Sumatra . . .” Lem never stopped talking while the leg was set. Nat was glad Polly wasn’t there to hear everything he said of Sumatra.

November 21 the *Putnam* sailed, “bound for Sumatra and the pepper islands, God willing” — Captain Bowditch commanding.

Captain Bowditch commanding. Nat looked about his ship and whispered those words to himself. He took his departure from Cape Ann. In his cabin, he marked his chart and started the log of the *Putnam*.

Billy Partel, his cabin boy entered. "Mr. Denny's compliments, sir. The watches are set."

Nat went on deck. Lupe's smile flashed, and was reefed. *Mr. Sanchez* now, second mate of the *Putnam*. A good man. A good crew, Nat thought. Old Chad Jensen at the wheel. Chad's grandson, young Corey, looked edgy. Probably hadn't found his sea legs yet. Good stuff in the boy.

Nat spoke to them quietly. He had good men in charge, he told them — Mr. Denny and Mr. Sanchez. They were to be obeyed at all times. He saw a flicker of bewilderment in the eyes of the crew. I suppose I should have roared, he told himself, but I can't think of anything to roar about. He told Mr. Denny and Mr. Sanchez he'd see them below at one bell.

When he talked to his mates he told them again — they were in charge. “Unless you need me, of course. But I don't expect you will.”

They said, “Aye, aye, sir!” They went above.

Then for the first time the awful aloneness hit him. He was responsible — finally and completely. All the long, lonely way to the Cape, all the treacherous, squally weeks in the Indian Ocean — he was responsible. No matter what came up, night or day, if it baffled his men, he must decide.

For the first time he began to understand Captain Prince — the set of his jaw and the bite of his words when a voyage began — the eternal alertness that never relaxed. He knew now why Prince always seemed to shed about ten years when they made their landfall.

He thought of his father, his sloop aground on Anguilla Reef. He imagined how it must have been to watch, helpless, while his future was beaten to pieces. He remembered how Granny had said, "It took the tuck out of him."

He remembered the threat of battle off Cadiz, when he had pulled off his shoes and had gone to the powder room. He had forgotten where he was — had worked problems on a powder keg. He couldn't forget now. If battle threatened, he couldn't let others make the decisions.

If they were challenged now, he must decide — if he'd surrender his ship — if his men would die defending it. If he lost a man, he must answer the faces on the wharf when he returned: Lupe's young bride — Denny's wife and the two boys . . .

Nat shook his head and went topside. He'd have to stop that way of thinking. Not twelve hours from home. He'd be gone twelve months — maybe longer. He was sailing to an uncharted coast, in an untried ship. No man knew yet how the *Putnam* would sail.

In the days that followed, the *Putnam* proved herself with flying colors. She passed the *Eliza*, that had sailed six days before the *Putnam* weighed anchor. The crew of the *Putnam* shouted and swaggered. A good omen that! They'd set a record!

In February, they stood off Capetown to fill their water casks and replenish supplies. Then the last familiar landmark faded astern. With luck, their next landfall would be Sumatra. Thousands of miles yet to go. The Cape seemed next door to the East Indies — till a man had sailed the Indian Ocean.

Ten days from the Cape, Billy came to Nat with wide eyes. "Mr. Denny's compliments, s-s-sir. Could you come on deck? All — all — well *something's* broken loose!"

Nat checked the glass. It was falling. He went topside.

Mr. Denny said, "Craziest thing I've ever seen, sir. Hardly enough wind to make sternway, and the waves are pounding us to pieces."

Nat studied the sky; huge cumulus clouds. Another wave crashed on the deck. "A typhoon, Mr. Denny.

The waves always outrun the wind. When the wind rises, we'll be able to make headway. We'll carry sail as long as possible. May outrun the storm."

Billy whispered, "How can we, sir? Typhoons move a hundred miles an hour, don't they?"

"They just go around that fast," Nat told him. "They don't move across the ocean at anything like that speed. You know how it is when you spin a top? It goes around very fast, and gradually moves across the floor?"

"Aye, aye, sir, I know about a top."

“Well, a typhoon — they call it a hurricane in the Caribbean — is just like a spinning wind-top. A huge top. It may be ten miles across — maybe twenty miles — maybe bigger. The air may be whirling around a hundred miles an hour. But the wind-top moves across the ocean rather slowly — maybe only eight or ten miles an hour. So it is possible to outrun one.”

“And — and — if we can’t, sir? What then?” Billy’s eyes were huge in his pale face.

“You heave to on a port tack — below the equator,” Nat told him. “I’ll tell you all about it some time, if you’d like to know.”

"Yes, sir : . . I mean — Aye, aye, sir. I'd like that fine."

The hours passed. Eight bells; the watch was relieved; eight bells again, and the starboard watch lay below. The clouds were strange shapes now and tinged with copper; the wind freshened.

"Mr. Denny, have a lifeline rigged," Nat ordered.

"Aye, aye, sir."

Men stretched a heavy line the length of the *Putnam* from bow to stern. More wind; the tophammer creaked. Lupe grinned and shouted, "Long as she creaks she holds, eh?"

The rain began — a thin, driving mist. Eight bells again. But no one lay below now. It was all hands on deck.

More wind. When Nat finally gave the order to reef sail, the men lay aloft on the double.

Huge waves crashed over the *Putnam*. The rain poured until men ducked their heads in a crooked elbow to breathe. Two men at the helm now. The *Putnam* rolled, scuppers under.

Lupe staggered to keep his footing and shouted in Nat's ear, "Got the worst of it now, eh?"

Nat didn't try to answer. He knew this was just the beginning. If they were sucked into the center of the whirling wind-top there wasn't a ghost of a chance.

At last the wind lessened. The glass began to rise. The huge waves still pounded them, the torrents of water still poured down, but the worst was over. The typhoon was passing them.

It was two days later before the skies cleared and Nat could check their position and set his course once more for Sumatra. In early May they sighted the loom of shadowy mountains off their starboard bow.

When they reached the latitude of Susu Bay, they stood off until the sun was behind them. Then Nat sent a man to the foremast to watch for the coral reefs, and two men to the chains to sound. Warily they inched their way through coral reefs to their anchorage.

Other Salem captains were there, loading pepper. They asked news of home. Nat told them “news” — as of last November — and asked about pepper. They shook their heads. Not much chance for another ship to load at Susu. Not for weeks.

Nat weighed anchor, beat his way out through the treacherous coral, to Pulu Coya. More Salem captains there. They, too, asked news of home. They, too, shook their heads over the prospects of another ship loading pepper. Not for many weeks, they said.

At last the *Putnam* anchored at Tully Pas. More men wanting word from home; more men shaking their heads over the prospects of pepper. Maybe — when all the ships in port were loaded — maybe he could get pepper.

Nat waited. He waited through days and nights of heat

that seemed to come from an oven. The decks of the *Putnam* oozed tar.

Every day he went ashore to the village. All around him the squat brown men of Sumatra spoke politely — and each carried a creese in the folds of his sarong. Their ruler, the dato, was very polite. The captains, he said, were paying ten dollars for a picul of pepper. Perhaps if the captain of the *Putnam* would pay eleven? Nat said he'd wait.

More days passed. The heat bore down. The fragrance of frangipani, honeysuckle, and jasmine grew heavy enough to strangle a man. Nat longed for the tang of a sea breeze off the North Atlantic.

The dato was more polite. Pepper was coming in more and more slowly, he said. He feared the crop was running low. Perhaps if the captain of the *Putnam* could advance a small sum — say a thousand or so silver dollars? Then the dato could urge his men to greater effort. Nat said he'd wait. The dato sighed . . . and fingered his creese.

That night Nat could not sleep. He went topside to pace the deck. Somewhere he heard a snore. He went forward. Corey, who was on watch, was sleeping. Nat spoke quietly. "Corey . . . Corey!"

His voice brought old Chad running up the hatchway. "What's wrong, Captain? Is he hurt?" Chad's voice cracked. "Is he dead?"

Corey started and mumbled. "What? Aye, aye, sir!"

Chad roared, "You! Asleep on your watch!" The tongue-lashing he gave his grandson brought the whole crew topside.

What was it, they asked. Had the Malays tried to board?

“If they had,” Nat roared, “you’d all be dead in your sleep!” He turned on his heel and went aft. There was nothing he needed to say to Corey. There was nothing he could say to the heartbroken old man who was Corey’s grandfather.

More days crawled by. At last the dato said he would have pepper for the *Putnam* tomorrow.

The next morning Nat gave Mr. Denny orders: he was to begin unloading ballast so he could store pepper. He was not, under any condition, to let more than two Malays on board ship at one time.

Nat took Lupe ashore with him. The boat crew landed the scales and a money chest, and carried them to the square. The boat returned to the *Putnam*. Lupe and Nat were alone, in a swarm of bandy-legged, barrel-chested, powerful brown men. More and more men swarmed into the square with their baskets of pepper to be weighed and stored in bags.

Finally the pepper bags made a wall, shoulder high. If the captain would pay now, the dato said, the men would begin taking the pepper to the ship. The price was . . . twelve dollars per picul.

Nat did not hesitate. He slammed down the lid on the money chest. "Mr. Sanchez, call a boat for us. We'll get pepper somewhere else."

Lupe's smile stretched; his eyes were flat black and watchful. He prowled from the square and left Nat alone in the swarm of Malays. Two minutes passed, three . . . and five. More brown men thronged into the square. A

violent argument rose. Nat wished he had had a grammar and dictionary of their language, too. It might have helped — to know what they were saying.

At last the dato approached him, smiling, his hand on his creese. It had been very hard work, he said, but he had persuaded the men to give up their pepper at eleven dollars a picul. The men were sad. It was choice pepper — the best of the season. That much was true, Nat knew. When the pepper began ripening in January, it ripened on the lower branches first. Not until May were the men harvesting the best of the crop.

Eleven dollars a picul? Nat opened the money chest again. When Lupe returned, the Malays were shouldering the pepper bags, and hurrying to the water's edge, loading their proas.

Lupe smiled again and this time the grin reached his eyes. "Señor," he drawled, "you are quite a guy."

Nat and Lupe went to the beach and watched the boats speed toward the *Putnam* — ten boats — more than fifty men. As they watched, a ladder dangled from the *Putnam*. Instantly a dozen Malays were laying hold, ready to climb. They could hear the angry shouts. Then they

saw Denny, Watson, and Jensen appear at the rail — with muskets. The Malays edged back. Two went on board.

Nat and Lupe returned to the square to buy more pepper. The next day the dato was sad. Why couldn't his men help on the *Putnam*? They could save the white men much work at stowing the cargo.

Lupe explained. With his mirthless smile and his watching eyes, he explained. Their captain, he said, was a harsh man. He liked to work his crew hard. "Also,"

he murmured to Nat, "we do our own work — we live longer, eh?"

June passed, and half of July. More ships anchored at Tully Pas. One morning when Nat went ashore, the dato spread his hands and sighed. The two hundred piculs he had promised for today — it would be impossible to get.

"I wonder," Lupe muttered, "how much who is paying for pepper? Now what? Do we — wait him out again?"

Nat smiled. "No — we don't wait him out. We sail.

We'll complete our cargo with coffee at the Isle of Bourbon or the Isle of France." He told Lupe of the two French islands east of Madagascar in the Indian Ocean. "I made my first sea voyage to Bourbon," he said. How long ago it seemed!

When they reached the Isle of France, three ships of Salem and Beverly were there. Polly's father, Captain Ingersoll, was just ready to weigh anchor. He came aboard the *Putnam* to see Nat and get news to take home to Polly. "How was it in Sumatra? Any trouble?"

"Oh, no," Nat told him, "quite uneventful."

Lupe's grin spread. "Captain Bowditch, he is one guy."

Captain Ingersoll cocked his head to one side. "So nothing happened, eh? I see . . . Well, I'll tell Polly all is well, and to look for you soon after I arrive. It shouldn't take you more than a week to load coffee here."

They cheered Captain Ingersoll on his way.

Nat said, "Mr. Denny, call the men aft."

Soon his men stood facing their captain — a tired crew, haggard with the long months of heat and the grinding toil of the passage to the Isle of France. He knew that

every man standing there wanted at least a week on shore before they sailed. He said, "Captain Ingersoll tells me there's plenty of coffee to complete our cargo. Then — when we've wooded, watered, and provisioned, we'll weigh anchor. And we won't wet that anchor again till Salem Harbor. Do we — bear a hand?"

They split the air with cheers. In five days the *Putnam* stood out from the island.

When Nat had taken his departure, he did some figuring. It had taken the *Henry* eleven weeks from Bourbon to Salem. The *Putnam* was faster. With luck, they'd be home in early November — maybe even the last of October.

They ran into a storm that night. For days they lived in wet clothes and ate cold food. The *Putnam* was rolling much too heavily for the cook to make fire in the galley. They doubled the Cape and fought head winds. No speed from the *Putnam* now; she seemed to crawl.

With a fair wind abaft the beam, the ship could have logged a hundred and fifty miles in a day's sailing. Now she fought head winds from tack to tack, and some day's sailing did not take her fifteen miles nearer home.

"When the storms are over," Lupe said, "we make up for it, eh?"

But the storms were never over. For several days at a time Nat was not able to take a sight. October passed; November came. With luck, Nat told himself now, they'd be home by early December. With good luck, he added.

In December they reached the Roaring Forties of the North Atlantic and groped their way, close hauled, in the teeth of the gales. At last the storms subsided.

At six bells of a forenoon watch, Nat said, "Mr. Denny, heave to for soundings."

Watson carried the deep-sea lead forward, and the other men followed, each with fakes of the line coiled in his hand — Collins on the cathead, Sandy in the fore chains, and Jensen in the main chains. Mr. Denny was on the quarter-deck with the rest of the line coiled.

Denny sang out, "All ready there, forward?"

Watson bellowed, "Aye, aye, sir!"

"Heave!"

“Watch, ho, watch!” It was Collins on the cathead.
“Watch, ho, watch!” From Sandy in the fore chains.
“Watch, ho, watch!” It was Jensen in the main chains.
Mr. Denny sang out, “Sixty fathoms!”

They hauled in the lead. Nat checked it. Black mud!
They were off Block Island.

“Block Island!” Lupe grinned. “Next door to home — and the storm is dying!” But the storm raged again, as though it had been gathering its strength for one more assault on the *Putnam*. Long days passed. The fifteenth of December, when they sounded, the lead brought up sand.

“Off Nantucket!” Lupe said. “I dress in my go-ashore clothes!” Then the stormy North Atlantic proved that all the other gales had been mere child’s play. For seven days and nights the *Putnam* was deluged and hammered.

At last the skies cleared. Nat made his observations. “I could have swum from Nantucket that fast!” he muttered.

Clouds darkened the sky again. For three days the rain poured in the waterfall torrents of tropical storms.

Only this rain was cold, and mixed with sleet. And men struggled with numb fingers to reef and loose sails.

In his cabin, Nat rested his head on his hands. He had hoped to be home in early November — with luck the end of October. Christmas Eve — and they weren't home yet.

Something clawed at his attention. He looked around, puzzled, then realized what it was. The wild rolling and pitching of the *Putnam* had lessened. At eight bells, Mr. Denny came to his cabin.

“The rain's letting up?” Nat asked.

“Aye, aye, sir.” Mr. Denny was grim. “This is worse.”

“Worse?”

“Yes, sir. Fog.” He shook his head slowly from side to side. “I’ve seen fogs in my day, but this one . . . ” He shrugged, and his shrug was a shiver. “*Fog!*”